

Ward Walton

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Diligent data professional with 3+ years of experience delivering actionable insights and end-to-end machine learning solutions. Skilled in SQL, Python, R, and statistical modeling, with experience across sports analytics, insurance, and AI product evaluation.

EXPERIENCE

Sportradar

September 2023 - Present

Broadcast Research Analyst

- Conduct player and team performance analysis across major U.S. sports to support high-profile broadcasts (NFL Playoffs, Super Bowl, March Madness) with accurate, insight-driven graphics and commentary.
- Utilize advanced SQL to query and analyze large historical sports datasets, supporting real-time client inquiries and identifying opportunities for data-driven storytelling.
- Led product evaluation for an LLM-based AI tool by developing domain-specific question sets, establishing ground-truth labels, and identifying systematic error patterns to improve model accuracy.

Sedgwick Claims Management Services

May 2022 – April 2023

Data Scientist

- Completed end-to-end data science projects such as fraudulent claim detection using unsupervised learning or large loss prediction with regression, combining skills in Dataiku, SQL, and R resulting in improved claim triage accuracy and reduced manual review workload.

Data Science Intern

- Developed a gradient boosting model to identify high-risk workers' compensation claims, streamlining the prioritization process for claims examiners, increasing examiners' prioritization efficiency and reducing claim settlement time.

Syracuse University Men's Lacrosse | Syracuse, NY

March 2022 - June 2022

Data Analytics & Sports Science Intern

- Managed data collection and analysis from wearable VXSport devices.
- Identified patterns of overexertion to inform and adjust practice strategies and load management.
- Designed, maintained, and presented to coaching staff daily dashboards visualizing player biometric data.

SKILLS

Programming: Python, R, SQL

Python: pandas, numpy, scikit-learn, matplotlib, BeautifulSoup

R: tidyverse, ggplot2

ML/Statistical: Classification, Regression, Clustering, Gradient Boosting, Feature Engineering, Model Evaluation

Tools: Dataiku, Git, Jupyter, Tableau, Power BI, Excel

Other: LLM evaluation, prompt engineering, product evaluation, web scraping

PROJECTS

NBA MVP Prediction Model

- Utilized machine learning techniques in Python to forecast NBA MVP award winners. Achieved an accuracy rate of 86% for past seasons, and correctly predicted the winner of the 2023-24 award.

Does Intercollegiate Sports Success Affect University Enrollment Outcomes?

- Explored the impact of FBS football success on university enrollment, assessing the effects of premier bowl game appearances, and overall television exposure on applicant numbers and acceptance rates. Revealed that on-field success and TV exposure significantly increased applications, particularly at smaller schools, with a more pronounced effect on male applicants.

Predicting NCAA Lacrosse Outcomes

- Sport Analytics program thesis analyzed over 3,500 NCAA men's lacrosse games from 2014-2021 using a tree-based random forest model. Demonstrated that offensive and defensive efficiency and faceoff win percentage contribute most to game outcomes.

EDUCATION

Syracuse University | Syracuse, NY

2018 – 2022

Bachelor of Science - Sport Analytics, Economics - GPA: 3.76

Achievements: Dean's List, Berlin Sport Analytics Scholar, Economics Distinction Program, & Omicron Delta Epsilon Economic Honor Society